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Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles

23–29 minutes

Data centres are critical infrastructure for Canada. They support the health care, financial services, research and secure government systems Canadians rely on, while powering artificial intelligence and creating new opportunities for communities and businesses. These opportunities must be pursued responsibly, with careful stewardship of electricity and water and meaningful involvement of host communities. These principles provide a common national framework for responsible data centre development.

1. Data centres must create lasting local benefits

Data centre investments must create clear, lasting benefits for host communities and Indigenous rights holders. These may include jobs, skills training and apprenticeships, local and Indigenous procurement, tax contributions, infrastructure investment, research partnerships and access to compute for local businesses and institutions. Proponents must engage early with host communities and Indigenous rights holders to identify benefits that reflect their priorities.

2. Data centres must not shift electricity costs to Canadians

Data centre growth must not shift project-driven electricity system costs onto households and existing businesses. Proponents must pay the costs of connecting and serving their projects, including new generation, transmission, substations and grid upgrades directly attributable to their development, proportionate to their scale and impact. Projects must not compromise grid reliability and, where required, must contribute new supply, infrastructure, storage or demand flexibility.

3. Data centres must minimize water use and environmental impacts

Data centres must minimize freshwater consumption and protect local water supplies, taking account of local conditions, resource constraints and overall environmental performance. Priority should be given to sustainable, low-impact technologies and practices, including closed-loop or high efficiency water technologies, waste heat recovery, and low-emission energy sources. Water use and other environmental impacts must be measured and transparently reported using recognized standards.

4. Data centres must be transparent about local impacts

Proponents must engage early and transparently with impacted local governments and Indigenous communities on data centre projects and respect local approval processes. They must provide clear, project-appropriate and independently verifiable information

on expected local impacts, including power and water use, infrastructure requirements, sound and emissions. Proponents must track and report on material commitments over time using measurable and independently verifiable information, while protecting security, privacy and confidential commercial information.

5. Data centres must bring strategic value to Canada

Data centre investments must create clear and lasting benefits for Canada, demonstrated through outcomes such as investment, tax revenue, Canadian supply-chain participation, innovation, research partnerships, workforce development and access to compute for Canadian businesses and institutions. Projects should strengthen Canada's long-term digital resilience, security and compute capacity. Facilities supporting sensitive data, public services, and critical infrastructure and systems must meet appropriate requirements for Canadian legal protection, cybersecurity, continuity of service and reliable Canadian access.

Signatories

AMD

"Canada's research leadership, skilled workforce and energy resources put the country in a strong position to compete in AI. Realizing that opportunity will require more than additional data centre capacity. It will require thoughtful development that supports communities and strengthens Canada's open innovation ecosystem. This framework provides a common foundation for

expanding access to advanced computing and helping Canadian researchers, businesses and public institutions turn innovation into long-term value."

Amazon Web Services (AWS)

"The digital services Canadians rely on every day, from healthcare and banking to the startups driving economic growth, depend on secure, reliable data centres. We've invested in Canadian communities through local workforce development, procurement of carbon-free energy, and building sustainable operations. Data centre growth must deliver real benefits for Canadians, and we look forward to continuing to work with governments to ensure data centres deliver lasting value to local communities."

Anthropic

"Canada's AI for All vision depends on world-class infrastructure built here at home. Data centres power the tools Canadians already use at work, at home and in public services. These principles set a clear standard for communities: responsible energy and water use, transparency and local jobs and investment. Anthropic is proud to sign on."

Beacon Data Centers

"Canada has every ingredient needed to become a global leader in artificial intelligence: talent, energy, innovation, and strong communities. These principles recognize that responsible data centre development can strengthen all four, and we're proud to stand with governments, municipalities, and industry in supporting them."

Bell Canada (BCE)

"For generations, Bell has built and operated the critical infrastructure Canadians rely on every day. As Canada builds for the next generation of innovation and economic growth, the federal government's principles provide an important framework for ensuring that AI infrastructure development delivers lasting benefits for communities and the country. Reflecting these principles, Bell AI Fabric is building the sovereign infrastructure foundation for Canada's AI future, combining advanced data centres, national connectivity and leading technology partners to expand Canada's AI capacity."

BUZZ High Performance Computing (BUZZ HPC)

"Canada does not have to choose between building the digital infrastructure our economy needs and building it responsibly. At BUZZ, we believe the next generation of data centres should create lasting benefits for Canadian communities, protect ratepayers and local resources, and strengthen Canada's national digital resilience. These principles provide an important foundation for building an industry that will be critical to Canada's economic competitiveness, security and innovation for decades to come. BUZZ is proud to sign on to Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles and help build the sovereign digital infrastructure that will support Canada's future."

Clearway Group of Companies

"Clearway supports the Government of Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles. Canada's growing demand

for AI and digital infrastructure presents a significant opportunity for investment, job creation and economic growth. Meeting that demand will require Canada to build quickly and responsibly, supported by a strong construction sector and skilled workforce. These principles provide an important foundation for delivering the infrastructure Canada needs to compete in the global digital economy."

Cohere

"Canada's strengths in talent and clean energy give us a real advantage in AI, but how we develop the infrastructure behind it will matter just as much. We welcome the government's focus on responsible development and making sure local communities see tangible benefits. For Canada to capture the full promise of AI, compute infrastructure deployed here must actively empower domestic innovators, researchers, public institutions, and the communities that they are based in. This framework sets the right direction to ensure the AI economy serves the broader Canadian public."

Cologix

Denvr Dataworks

"Building Canada's AI future is about more than adding compute capacity, it is about how that capacity is built, where it is built, and ensuring Canadians benefit from it. Denvr is proud to support the Responsible Data Centre Development Framework and its focus on responsible growth, strong communities and long-term value for Canada. As we continue to build sovereign AI infrastructure here at home, we believe Canada has an opportunity to

strengthen its digital resilience and security, support Canadian innovation, and ensure the infrastructure powering our digital economy delivers lasting benefits for generations to come."

EllisDon

"As Canada's leading data centre builder, we are proud to contribute to the build-out of the infrastructure required for Canada to compete and succeed. We support doing so in a responsible manner that ensures all Canadians benefit from the opportunities this infrastructure will provide. We fully support the Government of Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles."

Energy Storage Canada

"Energy Storage Canada welcomes the federal government's responsible data centre development framework. As Canada expands its digital infrastructure, energy storage can help enable that growth by providing greater flexibility, strengthening grid reliability and making more efficient use of existing electricity infrastructure."

Enwave Energy Corporation

"Enwave applauds Minister Solomon and the Government of Canada for the development of Canada's Responsible Data Centre Principles.

Guided by these principles—which prioritize energy-efficient data centre development—Canada can recognize its combined digital, energy and economic development goals.

Every day, Enwave works with our data centre partners to demonstrate these principles in action as we leverage district

energy to provide these facilities with more efficient cooling and leverage their waste heat as a valuable source of renewable energy for other district energy customers—generating better energy outcomes for all Canadians."

Equinix

"Equinix is proud to support the Government of Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles. Transparent, predictable guidelines like these reflect how Equinix operates and give Canadian communities the certainty and clarity they deserve as we continue to invest in the country. A partner to Canada for more than a decade, Equinix's investment now exceeds \$1.5 billion, with more than \$1 billion in additional projects currently underway, and more than 800 Canadians employed, as we deepen our long-term commitment. Equinix remains dedicated to putting these principles into practice, strengthening communities, creating jobs, and building the critical infrastructure that powers the digital future for the benefit of all Canadians."

eStruxture

"As the largest Canadian data centre operator, eStruxture is honoured to support the Canadian government's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles. The focus on economic benefits for local communities, affordable electricity, minimal water use and environmental impact, transparency, and projects that deliver strategic benefit will help ensure Canadian data centres are built with Canadian values. Signing on to these principles reinforces what eStruxture has practiced from day one. We look forward to working alongside the federal government and

municipal leaders across the country to build our digital future where it belongs – in Canada."

Global Relay

"Canada published its Responsible Data Centre Development Principles this week. The fifth principle says facilities supporting sensitive data, public services and critical infrastructure must meet appropriate requirements for Canadian legal protection, cybersecurity, continuity of service and reliable Canadian access. Canada needs technology vendors who will build, invest in and support local engineering firms and local supply. We are proud to operate a net-zero carbon data centre in British Columbia since 2013 that advances sovereign AI infrastructure while respecting water and energy resources. We're here to support Minister Evan Solomon's initiative to build the capacity Canada needs, build it responsibly and build it on Canadian terms."

Google

"Google is proud to support Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles, reflecting our core commitment to pay for 100% of the power we use along with infrastructure needs directly driven by our data center growth."

Hypertec Group

"Canada has an opportunity to lead not only in AI, but in how it is built. That starts with sustainable infrastructure that earns the trust of communities and creates lasting value for Canadians. By getting this right, Canada can turn responsible AI infrastructure

into a lasting competitive advantage."

IBM

"Trusted digital infrastructure is essential to Canada's economic growth and digital future. IBM is pleased to support Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles and the shared commitment to developing infrastructure that drives innovation, benefits communities and strengthens Canada's long-term competitiveness."

Intel

"Data centres have become the backbone of the digital economy, powering the expansion of AI. These principles provide a meaningful national framework for developing infrastructure responsibly and resiliently, while taking the interests of stakeholders into consideration. Intel is proud to support Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles, which align with our work to advance more energy-efficient and sustainable data centre technologies."

Kyndryl

"As AI adoption accelerates, Canada has a real opportunity to build digital infrastructure that is both powerful and responsible. At Kyndryl, we run the mission-critical systems Canadians rely on every day, from government services and banking to health care. Supporting AI growth isn't just about computing power. It's about resilient infrastructure, sustainable operations, investing in the communities we serve, and strong governance. These principles reflect how we already operate and will help position Canada for

long-term success."

Lenovo

"Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles provide an important framework for growing AI infrastructure responsibly and supporting Canadian innovation, while delivering benefits to communities and promoting the efficient use of natural resources. Lenovo's Neptune liquid-cooling technology can help expand sovereign compute capacity across Canada with greater energy efficiency and more sustainable operations."

Meta

"The Responsible Data Centre Development Principles provide clear standards for businesses investing in Canada and give Canadians confidence in what these projects will deliver. The Principles reflect the approach we are taking in Sturgeon County, Alberta, where we are investing more than CAD \$13 billion in our data centre and fully funding the new generation and grid infrastructure it requires — ensuring there is no impact on local ratepayers."

Micrologic

"Micrologic, a fully Canadian-owned company and sovereign cloud provider, supports the development of a Framework for Responsible Data Center Development in Canada. The proposed framework will bring greater certainty and confidence, for industry and citizens alike, that Canadian values are being maintained. It will also contribute to increased digital sovereignty for Canada and maximize the economics benefits, for Canadians, of our

investments in this rapidly growing and highly strategic sector."

Microsoft

"Canada's AI ambition depends on building the capacity to power it. We are proud to join the Federation of Canadian Municipalities and welcome the Government of Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles, which affirm that strong national infrastructure must also create strong local outcomes, aligning to our commitment to Community-First AI infrastructure. The real measure of success is not only how much Canada builds, but whether Canadians and their communities are better off because Canada built it."

NVIDIA

"AI is essential infrastructure. Every country will build it, and we have a responsibility to build it sustainably and in a way that benefits communities. Canada has extraordinary advantages in energy, talent, research and industry. These principles will help Canada continue to build AI infrastructure that strengthens communities, expand its sovereign computing capacity and create opportunities for generations to come."

OnX

"We commend Minister Solomon for establishing a thoughtful national framework for responsible data centre development. As Canada's demand for AI and digital infrastructure accelerates, we must ensure that this growth delivers lasting benefits for Canadians, strengthening our communities, protecting our natural resources and energy systems, and expanding the secure,

resilient computing capacity that Canada needs to compete globally."

OpenAI

"All politics are local, and all data centers are local. The only way to build infrastructure at this scale is to earn the trust of the communities that make it possible. That means listening early, paying our own way, protecting local resources, and making sure those communities share in the jobs, investment, and long-term economic value this infrastructure creates. The Government of Canada and Federation of Canadian Municipalities' principles provide a strong vision to create good jobs in their communities and the infrastructure that will help power the Canadian economy in a responsible, productive, and constructive way. When it comes to AI, the Canadian government 'sees the ice' they're not just reacting to the AI puck but are seeing the whole rink, anticipating where the technology is going and acting to best position the country to put the AI puck into the net to score real benefits for all of its people."

OVHcloud

"A pioneer of sustainable cloud in Europe, OVHcloud has been investing in Canada for 15 years, delivering trusted cloud solutions through an industrial model designed for the long term. From building our own data centres and assembling our servers to developing proprietary watercooling technology, we place circularity at the heart of our operations, helping reinforce Canada's digital resilience and strategic autonomy. We are proud to continue this commitment alongside partners who share our

ambition for the responsible development of Canada's digital infrastructure."

Potentia Renewables Inc.

"Meeting Canada's growing demand for digital infrastructure means meeting its growing demand for clean, reliable power, without pushing the costs onto Canadian households. Potentia is proud to stand behind a framework that ties data centre growth to real investment in the energy infrastructure and communities that make it possible."

Prologis

"Responsible data centre development starts with clear commitments and accountability. Canada's principles set a strong standard for early engagement and transparency, while protecting ratepayers and water resources. We're proud to support this effort as Canada builds the critical digital infrastructure it needs to compete and grow."

QScale

"Artificial intelligence is rapidly transforming our economy, and Canada has an opportunity to build the digital infrastructure that will support it right here at home. At QScale, we believe this growth must be responsible, powered by clean energy, efficient use of resources, and lasting benefits for communities. These principles are essential to making Canada a destination of choice for global investment in AI infrastructure."

Qu Data Centres

"Responsible development isn't something you commit to once. It's how you operate year after year. Qu Data Centres operates nine facilities that have been part of Canadian communities for decades, serving more than 750 organizations across health care, financial services, government, energy and more—the critical industries Canadians depend on every day. We were operating this infrastructure long before AI made data centres a national conversation, and we'll be accountable to the same neighbours long after. That's the standard these principles set and the one we intend to keep meeting."

Red Jar Energy Partners

"Red Jar Energy Partners supports Canada's development principles that put cost fairness for ratepayers, environmental responsibility, community benefit and transparency at the centre of how this industry grows. This framework reflects the standard we hold ourselves to, and we're glad to see it become the expected path for development. Responsibly managed data centres can deliver lasting value to communities and Canada."

Schneider Electric

"As demand for AI and digital services accelerates, Canada has an opportunity to become a global leader in sustainable data centre development. Schneider Electric supports a future where digital infrastructure is designed to be energy efficient, grid-supportive, transparent and beneficial to the communities it serves. Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles recognize that economic growth, environmental stewardship and energy reliability must go hand in hand. These

principles align closely with Schneider Electric's mission to enable a more electric and digital future, and we are proud to support their implementation across Canada."

Slate Asset Management

"This is an important step forward in establishing a responsible framework for data centre development and ensuring these investments deliver meaningful economic benefits for Canadians. The principles align closely with Ontario's approach to responsible data centre development, and strong federal-provincial collaboration will be critical to attracting investment, advancing sovereign AI infrastructure and positioning Ontario as a leader in the digital economy."

Sovereign Digital Infrastructure

"Alberta has always been a province that builds, and the next frontier is digital. At Sovereign Digital Infrastructure, we see an opportunity for the Peace River area to benefit from the AI economy. That's why we're proud to sign on to the Responsible AI Data Centre Development Framework. It reflects what we believe development should look like: rooted in strong communities, grounded in responsible growth, and built so that First Nations and all Albertans share in the investment, jobs, and lasting value these projects create for generations to come."

STACK Infrastructure

"Canada has a significant opportunity to advance the digital infrastructure that will power AI, innovation and economic growth for decades to come. STACK believes growth must be pursued

responsibly, in partnership with the communities where we build and operate, and with a focus on thoughtful resource stewardship and lasting local value. We are proud to support Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles and a shared commitment to building digital infrastructure that strengthens communities, supports economic growth and advances Canada's position in the global digital economy."

TELUS

"The global race for AI infrastructure is accelerating and Canada has a real opportunity to do it differently: responsibly, sustainably, and in a way that creates real value for our communities, protects our environment, and strengthens Canada's long-term economic resilience. TELUS has been guided by these same values as we build Canada's Sovereign AI facilities, and we're proud to commit to this framework alongside the industry and government."

ThinkOn

"ThinkOn is proud to stand behind a national framework that puts Canadian communities at the centre of how our industry grows. As a Canadian-owned cloud service provider, we believe responsible growth and digital sovereignty go hand in hand and these principles give companies like ours a shared standard to build towards. Canada has a genuine opportunity to be a leader in the data-driven age as a trusted voice on the world stage, but that leadership has to be earned responsibly and in partnership with the communities who host this infrastructure."

Urbacon Data Centre Solutions

"Urbacon Data Centre Solutions is 100 per cent Canadian-owned and has been developing data centres in Canada for over 37 years. We aren't developers passing through, we're neighbours who stay accountable to our communities decades later. These principles reflect how we already work, and why we're proud to formally commit to them."

Vantage Data Centres

"Canada's Responsible Data Centre Development Principles are an important step toward building the digital infrastructure the country needs in a way that earns public trust and delivers lasting value. By establishing clear expectations around community benefits, responsible resource management, transparency and ratepayer protection, the framework provides a common standard for responsible data centre development across Canada. These principles will encourage stronger collaboration among industry, governments, utilities and host communities, while creating greater consistency and accountability in how projects are developed. That foundation will help Canada expand its digital capacity responsibly and strengthen its long-term competitiveness in AI and the global digital economy."